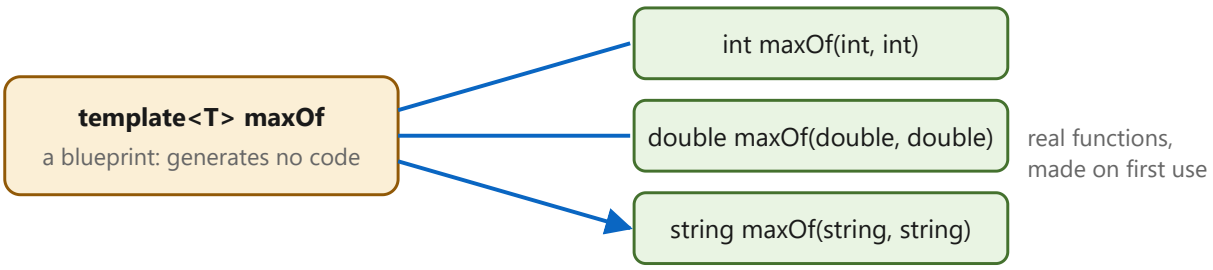
C++ Templates

Write code once, let the compiler generate it per type. From a first function template to forwarding references, variadics and type traits: the topics the job description lists.

Why templates, and function templates



Compile-time polymorphism: no runtime cost, more code per type.

Without templates: `maxInt`, `maxDouble`, `maxString`... A **template** takes the type as a parameter:

```
template <typename T>
T maxOf(T a, T b) {
    return a < b ? b : a;
}

maxOf(3, 7);           // compiler deduces T = int
maxOf(2.5, 1.5);       // T = double
maxOf<double>(3, 2.5);// explicit: T = double, the int is converted
```

The template is not compiled itself. Each new type **instantiates** a real function: no runtime cost, more binary size, and errors appear only when a bad type is used.

KEY POINT Templates: **compile-time** (static) polymorphism, fastest, inlinable, more code, types known at compile time. Virtual: **runtime**, one code path, mixed objects, a vtable indirection.

Template argument deduction

When you call a function template, the compiler works out `T` from the arguments. The rule depends on the **shape of the parameter**, and it is the same rule `auto` uses.

PARAMETER	CALL	DEDUCED `T`	RULE
`T x` (by value)	`f(ci)` with `const int ci`	`int`	a copy: top-level `const` and references are **dropped**
`T x` (by value)	`f(arr)` with `int arr[3]`	`int*`	arrays and functions **decay** to pointers
`T& x`	`f(ci)`	`const int`	the reference keeps the argument's `const`
`T& x`	`f(arr)`	`int[3]`	an array keeps its size (usable to get its length)
`const T& x`	`f(5)`	`int`	binds temporaries; `const` is not part of `T`
`T&& x`	`f(i)` / `f(5)`	`int&` / `int`	forwarding reference (see Forwarding references)

Compiled and checked with `static_assert`: by value, `const int` deduced `int` and the array deduced `int*`; by reference they deduced `const int&` and `int(&)[3]`.

- Deduction looks only at the **arguments**, never at the return type, and **no conversions** happen: `maxOf(3, 2.5)` fails because `T` would be both `int` and `double`.
- Default arguments and braced lists do not take part in deduction: `f({1, 2})` cannot deduce `T`. Name `T` explicitly: `f<std::vector<int>>({1, 2})`.
- Name the type yourself when needed: `maxOf<double>(3, 2.5)`.

Class template argument deduction (C++17)

```
std::pair p{1, 2.5};                    // std::pair<int, double>
std::vector v{1, 2, 3};                 // std::vector<int>
std::array a{1, 2, 3};                  // std::array<int, 3>

template <typename T> struct Box { T value; };
template <typename T> Box(T) -> Box<T>; // a user-defined deduction guide
(needed for aggregates before C++20)
Box b{std::string("x")};                // Box<std::string>
```

The compiler deduces the class's arguments from the constructor call. A **deduction guide** tells it how when the constructors alone are not enough. All of the above was compiled and checked.

> **WHEN DEDUCTION FAILS** The error says "couldn't deduce template parameter". Look for conflicting arguments, a braced list, or a parameter that does not mention `T` at all (e.g. only the return type does).

Class templates

Same idea for classes: `vector<T>`, `map<K,V>`, `unique_ptr<T>`.

```
template <typename T, std::size_t Capacity = 8>      // a type parameter, a
NON-TYPE parameter, with a default
class Stack {
    std::array<T, Capacity> items_;
    std::size_t size_ = 0;
public:
    bool push(const T& v) {
        if (size_ == Capacity) return false;
        items_[size_++] = v;
        return true;
    }
    T pop() { return items_[--size_]; }
    bool empty() const { return size_ == 0; }
};

Stack<int> a;                // Stack<int, 8>
Stack<std::string, 100> b;   // a different, unrelated type

std::pair p{1, 2.5};         // C++17 CTAD: class template argument deduction
→ std::pair<int, double>
std::vector v{1, 2, 3};      // std::vector<int>
```

- **Non-type parameters** are compile-time constants (how `std::array<int,5>` knows its size).
- Each instantiation is a separate, unrelated class. Members are instantiated only if called.

> **WHY TEMPLATES LIVE IN HEADERS** The compiler needs the body at instantiation. In a `.cpp`, others see only a declaration: linker errors. Use headers, or explicit instantiation (`template class Stack<int>;`).

Specialization

A **specialization** replaces the generic template for specific arguments.

```
template <typename T>
struct Printer {                                // primary template
    static void print(const T& v) { std::cout << v << '\n'; }
};

template <>                                     // full specialization for bool
struct Printer<bool> {
    static void print(bool v) { std::cout << (v ? "yes" : "no") << '\n'; }
};

template <typename T>
struct Printer<T*> {                            // PARTIAL specialization: any
pointer type
    static void print(T* p) { std::cout << "ptr to " << *p << '\n'; }
};
```

KIND	MEANING	ALLOWED FOR
Full specialization	all parameters fixed: `template<> ... Printer<bool>`	class and function templates
Partial specialization	a pattern: `Printer<T*>`	**class templates only**

> **FUNCTIONS: PREFER OVERLOADS** No partial specialization for function templates.
>
> Overload instead; an exact non-template match wins. Function specializations do not take part in overload resolution.

Variadic templates and fold expressions

A **parameter pack** (`typename ... Args`) takes any number of arguments; `args ...` expands it. Before C++17: recursion with a base case.

```
template <typename T>
T sum(T v) { return v; }                                    // base case: one
argument

template <typename T, typename ... Rest>
T sum(T first, Rest ... rest) { return first + sum(rest ...); }    // peel one
off, recurse

sum(1, 2, 3);
```

The compiler instantiates a chain of real functions.

C++17 **fold expressions** replace the recursion:

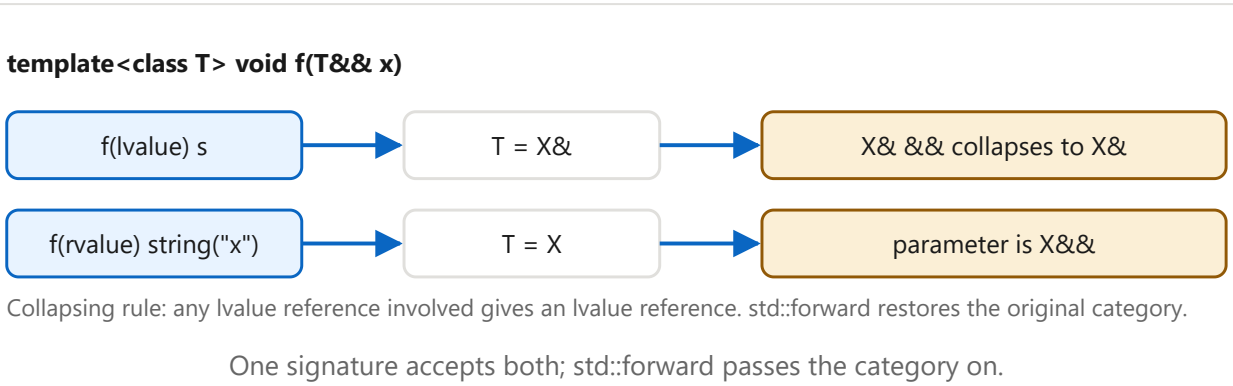
```
template <typename ... Args>
auto sum(Args ... args) { return (args + ...); }          // unary right fold:
a + (b + (c ...))

template <typename ... Args>
void print(Args&& ... args) { ((std::cout << args << ' '), ...); }   // comma
fold: do it for each arg

sizeof ...(Args);                                          // number of
elements in the pack
```

Behind `make_unique`, `make_shared`, `emplace_back`, `tuple`, `thread`, `function`.

Forwarding references and perfect forwarding



`T&&` **in a function template** is a **forwarding reference**, not an rvalue reference: it binds to anything and remembers lvalue vs rvalue.

Is it really a forwarding reference?

Only when `T` is deduced for *that* function and the form is exactly `T&&` or `auto&&`:

DECLARATION	FORWARDING REFERENCE?
`template<class T> void f(T&& x)`	yes: `T` is deduced for `f`
`auto&& x = expr;`	yes
`template<class T> void f(std::vector<T>&& v)`	no: not exactly `T&&`, so it binds rvalues only
`template<class T> void f(const T&& x)`	no: `const` disqualifies it
`template<class T> struct S { void f(T&& x); };`	no: `T` is fixed by the class, so nothing is deduced for `f`
`void f(Widget&& w)`	no: a plain rvalue reference

Reference collapsing

Reference to reference collapses: **any lvalue reference makes it an lvalue reference; only `&& + &&` stays rvalue.**

WRITTEN	COLLAPSES TO
`T& &`, `T& &&`, `T&& &`	`T&`
`T&& &&`	`T&&`

Perfect forwarding

A wrapper's parameter has a *name*, so it is an lvalue and the callee would always copy. `std::forward` restores the category:

```
template <typename T, typename ... Args>
std::unique_ptr<T> makeUnique(Args&& ... args) {                    //
forwarding references
    return std::unique_ptr<T>(new T(std::forward<Args>(args) ... ));  //
lvalues stay lvalues, rvalues stay rvalues
}

std::string s = "abc";
auto a = makeUnique<Widget>(s);              // s is an lvalue  → Widget
copies it
auto b = makeUnique<Widget>(std::string("x"));// temporary rvalue → Widget
MOVES it
```

STD::MOVE VS STD::FORWARD `move` *always* casts to rvalue. `forward<T>` casts to rvalue *only if* the argument was one. Use `forward` only on a forwarding reference, once.

Alias templates, variable templates and more

TOOL	EXAMPLE	USE
Alias template	`template <typename T> using Table = std::map<std::string, std::vector<T>>;`	a shorter name that still takes a parameter; unlike `typedef` it can be templated
Variable template (C++14)	`template <typename T> constexpr T zero = T{};`	a constant per type: `zero<int>`, `zero<double>`. The standard's `std::is_integral_v<T>` is one
Template template parameter	`template <template <typename ...> class C, typename T>`	pass a *template* (`std::vector`) rather than a type: `makeTwo<std::vector>(3, 4)`
Non-type parameter	`template <typename T, std::size_t N>`	a value as parameter; `auto` accepts any type of value in C++17: `template <auto V>`
Abbreviated template (C++20)	`void f(auto x)`	each `auto` parameter is an implicit template parameter

```
template <typename T> using Table = std::map<std::string, std::vector<T>>;
Table<int> t;                                   // std::map<std::string,
std::vector<int>>

template <typename T> constexpr T zero = T{};        // zero<int> is 0,
zero<double> is 0.0

template <template <typename ...> class Container, typename T>
Container<T> makeTwo(T a, T b) { Container<T> c; c.push_back(a);
c.push_back(b); return c; }
auto v = makeTwo<std::vector>(3, 4);                 // a vector<int> with
two elements
```

Unpacking with `std::index_sequence`

To call a function with the elements of a `std::tuple` you need the indices `0, 1, 2 ...` as a pack. `std::make_index_sequence<N>` generates it:

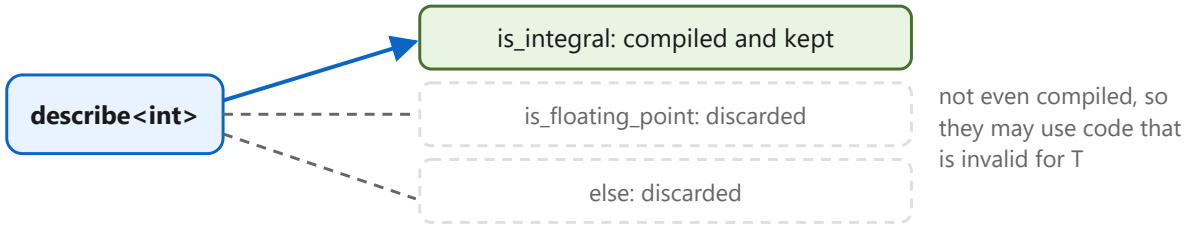
```
template <typename F, typename Tuple, std::size_t ... I>
auto applyImpl(F f, const Tuple& t, std::index_sequence<I ... >) { return
f(std::get<I>(t) ... ); }   // expands to get<0>, get<1>, ...

template <typename F, typename Tuple>
auto applyTuple(F f, const Tuple& t) { return applyImpl(f, t,
std::make_index_sequence<std::tuple_size_v<Tuple>>{}); }

applyTuple([](int x, int y, int z) { return x + y + z; }, std::tuple{1, 2,
3});   // 6 (compiled)
```

C++17 ships this as `std::apply`. Know the idea: a pack of integers lets you expand an expression once per element.

Type traits and `if constexpr`



A normal if would fail to compile as soon as one branch is invalid for T.

A template often needs to ask about its type. `<type_traits>` answers at compile time (`std::is_integral_v<T>`), and `if constexpr` (C++17) keeps only the matching branch:

```
template <typename T>
std::string describe(const T& v) {
    if constexpr (std::is_integral_v<T>)           return "integer "   +
std::to_string(v);
    else if constexpr (std::is_floating_point_v<T>) return "float "     +
std::to_string(v);
    else                                           return "something else";
}
```

Traits, SFINAE and `enable_if`, concepts, `constexpr`, `consteval` and template metaprogramming have their own lesson: Type Traits & Compile-time C++.

Pitfalls and good practice

PITFALL	EXPLANATION / FIX
Huge unreadable error messages	The error is reported deep inside an instantiation. Read the *first* error and the line "required from here". Concepts or `static_assert` on traits give early, clear errors.
Template body in a `.cpp` file	Linker errors. Put the definition in the header.
`typename` for dependent types	Inside a template, `T::iterator` could be a type or a value. Write `typename T::iterator it;`.
Members of a dependent base class not found	Write `this->member` or `Base<T>::member`.
Code bloat	Every distinct `T` generates more machine code. Move type-independent logic into a non-template helper.
Deduction conflicts: `maxOf(3, 2.5)`	Two different deduced `T`s fail. Cast, specify `maxOf<double>`, or use two parameters.
`maxOf("a", "b")` with `const char*`	Compares pointer addresses, not text. Use `std::string` or `std::string_view`.

Notes: Module 4; modern-cpp-features.

FURTHER READING

C++ Primer (Lippman, Lajoie, Moo)

- 16.1 Defining a template (PDF pages 681 to 706)
- 16.2 Template argument deduction (PDF pages 707 to 722)
- 16.3 Overloading and templates (PDF pages 723 to 727)
- 16.5 Template specializations (PDF pages 735 to 743)
- 16.4 Variadic templates (PDF pages 728 to 734)

Effective Modern C++ (Meyers)

- Item 1, Understand template type deduction (PDF pages 27 to 36)
- Item 23, Understand std::move and std::forward (PDF pages 176 to 182)
- Item 24, Distinguish universal references from rvalue references (PDF pages 182 to 186)
- Items 26 to 27, and 30 Overloading on universal references; perfect forwarding failure cases (PDF pages 195 to 215 and 225 to 232)

Programming: Principles and Practice (Stroustrup)

- 18.1 to 18.3 Templates, generalizing Vector, range checking and exceptions (PDF pages 527 to 541)

C++ Move Semantics (Josuttis)

- 9.1 to 9.3 Perfect forwarding; universal versus rvalue references (PDF pages 159 to 166)
- 9.4 to 9.5 Overload resolution with universal references; perfect forwarding in lambdas (PDF pages 167 to 170)
- Chapter 11 Perfect passing with auto&& (PDF pages 191 to 202)
- Chapter 12 Perfect returning with decltype(auto) (PDF pages 203 to 210)